

Japan, *February 2027*

Three weeks across Tokyo, the mountains, Kyoto's old streets, and a snow week in Nozawa. Nine of us, three generations, one big birthday.

DATES

2 — 25 Feb

NIGHTS

23

OF US

9

The crew

Dad

The 70-year-old

Mum

Gray

Sophie

Jess

Ben

Florence

9

Juniper

6

Goldie

2

The shape of the trip

LEG 01 · 4 NIGHTS

Tokyo

Tue 2 — Sat 6 Feb

Land late, ease in. A buffer for jetlag, body clocks, and the toddler. Big-city anchor experiences before we head into the mountains.

- Tue 2 **TRAVEL** Brisbane → Tokyo Narita, lands **17:30**. Transfer to hotel (~90 min). Conbini / hotel dinner — likely settled by 21:00.
- Wed 3 **ANCHOR** Morning: **Kappabashi-dori** kitchen town (knives, ceramics, plastic food samples). Afternoon: **Setsubun at Sensō-ji** — bean-throwing festival, oni costumes.
- Thu 4 **ANCHOR** Morning: **Tsukiji Outer Market** — sashimi breakfast, market wander. Afternoon: **Hama-rikyu Gardens** + tea house on the pond island.
- Fri 5 **ANCHOR** **Sumo morning practice** (6:30am, adult split-cohort, Ryōgoku). Afternoon: depachika browse (Mitsukoshi / Isetan). Early night before Hakone.

LEG 02 · 2 NIGHTS

Hakone

Sat 6 — Mon 8 Feb

Onsen town. Mt Fuji views, volcanic valleys, and the slow-down day before Kyoto.

- Sat 6 **TRAVEL** Tokyo → Hakone on Odakyu Romancecar (~85 min). Lunch in Yumoto. Afternoon: **Hakone Open-Air Museum**. Check in to ryokan, onsen + kaiseki dinner.
- Sun 7 **ANCHOR** **The Hakone Loop** — Tozan switchback railway → cable car → ropeway over Owakudani (volcanic valley, black eggs) → pirate ship across Lake Ashi (Fuji views) → Hakone Shrine (torii in the water) → bus back.

The cultural heart and the depth leg. Eight nights to slow right down — temples, machiya streets, sake breweries, master craft. Wide day-trip range: Himeji, Nara, Fushimi sake, Yamazaki distillery, Osaka half-day, Kaiyukan aquarium.

- | | | |
|--------|---------------|---|
| Mon 8 | TRAVEL | Hakone → Kyoto via shinkansen (~2 hr 15). Check in. |
| Tue 9 | ANCHOR | Higashiyama / Gion day — Kiyomizu-dera, Sannenzaka/Ninenzaka, Yasaka Shrine, Gion wander. Optional free walking tour in the morning. |
| Wed 10 | ANCHOR | Fushimi day — Inari shrine 1000 torii morning, Fushimi sake district afternoon (Gekkeikan museum + tasting, Kizakura). |
| Thu 11 | ANCHOR | Morning: Nara half-day — Tōdai-ji giant Buddha + deer park. Afternoon back in Kyoto. |
| Fri 12 | ANCHOR | Himeji Castle day trip (~50 min shinkansen). Keep climb + Koko-en gardens. Split-cohort if Goldie skips the keep. |
| Sat 13 | ANCHOR | Kids day — Toei Kyoto Studio Park (samurai film set, ninja shows, costume dress-up) + Kyoto Railway Museum. |
| Sun 14 | ANCHOR | Yamazaki + Kaiyukan day — split cohort, adults distillery / kids aquarium. |
| Mon 15 | FREE | Morning: forward bags to Nozawa via Yamato Takkyubin (arrives Tue). Afternoon: free / last Kyoto wander. |

LEG 04 · 5 NIGHTS — LOCKED

Nozawa Onsen

Tue 16 — Sun 21 Feb

The snow week. Skiing for those who want it, 13 free public bathhouses, and Sparena for the lower-pressure mixed-bathing option. Nozawa Dream Central is the target accommodation.

- | | | |
|--------|--------|--|
| Tue 16 | TRAVEL | Kyoto → Tokyo → Iiyama → Nozawa (~5 hr door-to-door). Daypacks only — bags arrive separately. 9am Kyoto → ~2:30pm Nozawa . Check in, onsen, settle. |
| Wed 17 | ANCHOR | Ski day 1 . Girls in lessons. Non-skiers: village + Sparena + Sakaya Honten sake. |
| Thu 18 | ANCHOR | Ski day 2 . Non-skiers optional Nagano + Obuse day-trip (Zenkō-ji, Hokusai Museum, Masuichi-Ichimura sake). |
| Fri 19 | ANCHOR | Ski day 3 . Non-skiers: village + onsen + relaxed pace. |
| Sat 20 | FREE | Chill day . Onsen, Sparena, slow village wander, pack. Everyone wind-down. |

LEG 05 · 4 NIGHTS

Tokyo

Sun 21 — Thu 25 Feb

Back to the city for the wind-down. The sushi-counter dinner. The last surprise. The slow re-pack.

- | | | |
|--------|--------|---|
| Sun 21 | TRAVEL | Nozawa → Tokyo (~2.5–3 hr door-to-door). 9am Nozawa → ~12:30pm Tokyo. Daypacks only — bags forwarded Sat. |
| Mon 22 | ANCHOR | Dad's golf day — Ginza morning (Honma + Mizuno flagships), Kanda Ogawamachi afternoon (Victoria Golf + sports street browse). |
| Tue 23 | ANCHOR | Morning: Ghibli Museum (Mitaka — book tickets 10am JST on 10 Jan 2027). Evening: Dad's birthday dinner — sushi counter. |
| Wed 24 | ANCHOR | teamLab Planets (Toyosu — barefoot water immersive) + Small Worlds Tokyo (Ariake — model city park, get inserted as figurines). |

● Travel day ● Anchor day ● Free day

Where we're at

LOCKED IN

Flights (Brisbane → Narita, 2 Feb 17:30)

Nozawa dates (16–21 Feb)

5-leg itinerary shape

Osaka cut — Yamazaki, Kaiyukan, Castle as Kyoto day-trips

OPEN THREADS

Nozawa Dream Central — confirm dates + breakfast

Accommodation per leg (9 of us)

Activity bookings (Yamazaki, sushi, etc.)

Share with the family group